

Brutalism

Brutalism's name, from the French term *béton brut* ('rough concrete') puns on the style's 'brutal' aspects that polarized opinion in its 1950 to 1970s heyday. Proponents saw it as a riposte to the blandness of modernism, but critics decry its cold, totalitarian look. Brutalist architecture is strong-looking and dominated by raw, exposed concrete, or steel and brick or rough-hewn stone, often with repeated modular elements. Its low cost saw it taken up around the world for institutional buildings and housing estates during the post-war era. The influential 1956 London exhibition *This is Tomorrow*, featuring artists, musicians and architects, included several exponents of brutalism: James Stirling, Ernó Goldfinger (1902–87) and Alison (1928–94) and Peter (1923–2003) Smithson. Le Corbusier famously used *béton brut* for his Unité d'Habitation in France (1952) and 1953 Secretariat Building in Chandigarh, India. Notable brutalist buildings in the United States include the Yale Art & Architecture Building (1963) by Paul Rudolph and Le Corbusier's Carpenter Center at Harvard (also 1963).



Trellick Tower in London, Goldfinger, 1966–72